

Strip 10

One channel of a compact analogue mixer, laid out sideways: a clean preamp, a low cut, a one-knob compressor, three-band EQ, pan and fader.



Overview

Strip 10 is one channel of a compact analogue mixer, laid out sideways, so its controls run left to right in signal order: GAIN, HPF, COMP, HIGH / MID / LOW, PAN and the LEVEL fader. It is in the spirit of the small ten-channel desks with a one-knob compressor on the mic inputs: simple, quick and honest, with nothing to get lost in.

The preamp is clean, with about 14 dB of headroom above 0 dBFS. At sensible levels it is transparent; push it hard and it adds a touch of warm, even-harmonic colour, then rounds off softly at its rails. The compressor is a single knob that lowers the threshold, raises the ratio and adds make-up gain all together. The EQ is the broad, forgiving kind found on such mixers, with a fixed 2.5 kHz mid.

By default the channel is mono, like the real thing: the two inputs are summed and PAN places the result. Switch INPUT to STEREO and both sides run through the same strip, with PAN becoming a balance control.

Reach for it for

- Quick, no-fuss treatment of vocals, guitars, kick, snare and bass
- Podcast and spoken-word voices that need levelling and a little presence
- Clearing rumble with a single low-cut key
- A touch of preamp warmth from pushing GAIN hard
- Placing a mono source in the stereo field

Controls

The header

PRESETS

Opens the list of factory presets (a click on the preset

	display does the same).
◀ / ▶	Step to the previous or next preset (wrapping round).
Preset display	The LCD shows the preset number (PRESET 01/08) over its name.
MONO / STEREO (INPUT)	MONO (the default) sums the two inputs at -6 dB each, so a mono source on a stereo track passes at unity, and PAN places it. STEREO runs both sides through the same strip, with the compressor linked, and PAN becomes a balance control (the title changes to BAL). Switching between them crossfades, so it never clicks.
DRIFT	How much the mixer's supply wanders, 0 to 100% (15% by default). See Drift below. Its value shows beside it while you touch it.
OFF / CLIP / LIMIT	The final stage: nothing, a soft clipper at -0.3 dBFS (the default, no latency), or a lookahead limiter that holds the peaks at -0.3 dBFS (3 ms latency, compensated by REAPER). While the output clips, the CLIP key flashes red.
S / M / L	Panel size: small, medium or large. The panel also scales to fit the plugin window. A new instance opens at L.
?	Opens a pop-up with the design credit, the GFX website address and the address of this manual. Click anywhere to close it.

GAIN

GAIN (cream cap)	The preamp, -20 to +40 dB (0 dB by default). Clean at sensible levels; driven hard it adds a little even-harmonic warmth, then a soft, round limit.
PEAK	A red LED. It lights, and holds for a moment, when the signal after the preamp or after the EQ reaches -3 dBFS.

HPF

80 Hz (LOW CUT)

Switches in an 80 Hz high-pass filter, 12 dB per octave, to clear rumble, handling noise and boom. Off by default. It crossfades in and out, so it never clicks.

COMP**COMP (orange cap)**

The one-knob compressor, 0 to MAX (0 by default). Turning it up lowers the threshold from -2 to -26 dBFS, raises the ratio from 1:1 to 4:1 and adds automatic make-up gain, matched for peaks around -12 dBFS. While you touch it, it shows the ratio and threshold (e.g. 2.5:1 -14 dB). It has a fast, musical attack (about 5 ms), a medium release (about 160 ms) and a soft knee, and it holds its peaks briefly so low notes do not ripple. At 0 it is out of circuit completely.

COMP LED

An amber LED that glows brighter the more gain reduction there is.

EQ: HIGH, MID, LOW

A broad three-band EQ, after the compressor. Each knob has a centre mark at 0; the gains glide smoothly, so you can turn them while the track plays.

HIGH (blue cap)

A high shelf at 10 kHz, -15 to +15 dB (0 dB by default).

MID (green cap)

A broad bell at 2.5 kHz (fixed), -15 to +15 dB (0 dB by default).

LOW (red cap)

A low shelf at 100 Hz, -15 to +15 dB (0 dB by default).

PAN**PAN / BAL (small cap)**

L 100 to R 100, centre (C) by default. In MONO it is a constant-power pan pot, set so the centre is unity (hard left or right is +3 dB on that side). In STEREO it becomes BAL: unity in the centre, the far side fading out as you turn.

LEVEL

LEVEL fader	The channel fader, OFF (-inf) to +10 dB, 0 dB by default. It has a real fader taper, printed OFF, -40, -20, -10, 0 and +10, with 0 dB at three quarters of the travel. Drag the cap sideways (Shift for fine moves), click the slot to jump there, use the mouse wheel, or double-click for 0 dB. While you touch it, its value replaces the LEVEL title.
L / R meter	Two rows of ten LEDs showing the output level, -42 to 0 dBFS (green, then amber from -6, red at the top).

Drift

DRIFT lets the mixer's supply wander slowly, as it never quite sits still on real hardware. Each part of the circuit feels it a little differently: the preamp gain eases by up to 0.3 dB, the EQ gains by up to 3% (and their frequencies by a hair), and the fader level very slightly. At 0% the channel stays exactly where you set it; higher settings also make the wander a little faster.

Knobs: drag up or down (Shift for fine moves) or use the mouse wheel; double-click to reset a knob to its default. Values show while you hover over or turn a control.

Presets

Presets set GAIN, HPF, COMP, the EQ, PAN and LEVEL. INPUT, DRIFT and the output stage are left as they are, except by Init.

Init	Everything back to the defaults: flat, compressor off, centre, 0 dB, MONO, DRIFT 15%, CLIP.
Vocal	Low cut in, a moderate squeeze, +3 dB of high, a little mid and -2 dB of low.
Acoustic Guitar	Low cut in, light compression, a brighter top with the 2.5 kHz and 100 Hz areas pulled back.
Kick	+5 dB of low and +3 dB at 2.5 kHz for the beater, with medium compression.
Bass DI	Firmer compression, a softer top and a little more low and mid.

Snare	Low cut in, medium compression, +4 dB of high and +2 dB of mid for crack.
Podcast Voice	GAIN up 3 dB, low cut in and heavy compression for an even, upfront voice with presence.
Keys	A light touch: gentle compression, a little sparkle, a small mid dip and a hint of low.

Tips

- Set GAIN first: turn it up until the PEAK LED flickers on the loudest notes, then back it off a little.
- On almost anything other than kick and bass, press the 80 Hz key before you touch the EQ.
- The COMP knob's make-up gain is matched for peaks around -12 dBFS, so set GAIN to suit before judging how much compression sounds right.
- For a stereo source such as keys or an overhead pair, switch INPUT to STEREO, or the two sides will be summed to mono.
- Use the LEVEL fader, not GAIN, to balance the channel in the mix: GAIN changes how hard the compressor works.
- Set DRIFT to 0 for a static, repeatable channel.

File: gfx-strip-10.jsfx